

CASE ID: 199109710220

EPISODE NAME: China Threatens France over Arms Sales to Taiwan 1991

1991/09/29 - 1994/01/12

Sender: China (710)

Target: France (220)

Issue: End Weapons/Materials Proliferation (9)

Final Outcome: Stalemate in the Threat Stage (4)

Summary:

On 1991/09/06, it was reported that Taiwan had signed a contract with France to buy six light frigates and the technology to build ten more.¹ China responded by alluding to a potential breakdown in relations on 1991/09/29.² China did not act upon their threat to damage relations with France, and relations between China and France were not formally downgraded until after future arms sales between the countries.³

Narrative:

On 1991/09/06, it was reported that France had signed a contract with Taiwan to buy six light frigates and the technology to build ten more.⁴ The contract was signed in 1991/05, with details of the technology transfer determined on or before 1991/10/09.⁵ On 1991/09/29, China expressed “strong dissatisfaction,” and responded by threatening, in effect, that the decision would result in a breakdown of relations between the countries, with Chinese Vice Foreign Minister Tian Zengpei saying, “This is a serious matter in Sino-French relations.”⁶

Taiwan agreed to buy the frigates, without weapons systems included, for 11 billion francs.⁷ The sale came after France had capitulated on plans to sell frigates to Taiwan a year earlier under

¹ “Taiwan signs contract for six French light frigates.” *South China Morning Post*, September 6th, 1991.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1541007690/77057EF694A04C72PQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

² OS. “China scolds France over Taiwan deal.” *Orlando Sentinel*, 29 Sept. 1991.

³ UPI. “China orders France to close consulate over Taiwan jets” *United Press International*, 23 Dec. 1992.
<https://www.upi.com/Archives/1992/12/23/China-orders-France-to-close-consulate-over-Taiwan-jets/7165725086800/>

⁴ “Taiwan signs contract for six French light frigates.” *South China Morning Post*, September 6th, 1991.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1541007690/7F5F3B4141B1497DPQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

⁵ “French seal frigate deal with Taiwan.” *South China Morning Post*, October 9th, 1991.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1753658021/3655AAD15DE9415DPQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

⁶ “China scolds France over Taiwan deal.” *Orlando Sentinel*, September 29th, 1991.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/277968123/913E00DB34114971PQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

⁷ “Taiwan signs contract for six French light frigates.” *South China Morning Post*, September 6th, 1991.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1541007690/7F5F3B4141B1497DPQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

threat of frozen diplomatic relations by Beijing.⁸ China's criticism of this sale was milder than its criticism of the would-be sale a year earlier, and some French newspapers alleged that France had promised foreign aid to China as well, both leading to a decision by France to execute the sale this time.⁹ China did not act upon their threat to damage relations with France.

Relations continued between Paris and Beijing immediately following this episode. In 1992/03/09, France and Taiwan agreed to a second arms deal, after which China ordered France to close its consulate in Guangzhou and barred French companies from participating in a profitable subway project.¹⁰¹¹ The countries officially re-entered normal diplomatic relations on 1994/01/12.¹²

⁸ Chen, David. "Beijing Victory as Frigates Cancelled." *South China Morning Post*, January 12th, 1989. <https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540515036/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/5?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News> papers.

⁹ "French seal frigate deal with Taiwan." *South China Morning Post*, October 9th, 1991. <https://www.proquest.com/docview/1753658021/3655AAD15DE9415DPQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News> papers.

¹⁰ "China orders France to close consulate over Taiwan jets" *United Press International*, December 23rd, 1992. <https://www.upi.com/Archives/1992/12/23/China-orders-France-to-close-consulate-over-Taiwan-jets/7165725086800/>.

¹¹ Cohen, Roger. "France Bars Taiwan Sales, Warming China Ties." *The New York Times*, January 13th, 1994. <https://www.proquest.com/docview/109320882/6E1BDF121D44448PQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=Newspapers>.

¹² Ibid.